assistance to India. Moreover, on Capitol Hill, foreign aid in general and to South Asia in particular was under attack, and Secretary of State Dean Rusk observed a "strong Congressional urge that we get out" of India and Pakistan.[12] Thus officials stressed that as long as Delhi focused expenditure on defense rather than development, economic aid would not be forthcoming.[13]

The American attitude did not earn the US any friends in India. Chester Bowles, ambassador to India, reported that public sentiment in India focused not on Washington urging Delhi to fix its spending priorities but on allegations that the US was using aid to force India to make concessions to Pakistan or to take a pro-US stance on Vietnam.[14]

India: Too Big to Fail

The logic of US involvement in Asia at the time did not leave room for disengagement from India. According to Robert Komer, now deputy national security adviser, one of the basic propositions that the US just could not get around was that "India is (with Japan) one of the two really key countries in Free Asia—so merits a comparable investment almost despite the Indians."[15] Robert McNamara argued that greater US investment in South Vietnam only made sense if the US continued to shore up the other fronts, including the India-Pakistan one, in the "long-run effort to contain China."[16]

While there was little American interest in resuming military aid to India, there was concern in the National Security Council about turning the economic tap off. McGeorge (Mac) Bundy believed that the first principle when considering future US policy toward South Asia should be that "India is more important than Pakistan and there is enough hope in India to justify continued support by food and economic aid if the Indians in turn are reasonable with us."[17]

It was not hope in India, however, that drove Johnson to turn the tap back on again; it was fear that the country would fail. While his advisers had been selling India's potential strength, the president had become even more concerned about the country's internal and external vulnerabilities: "I don't see how this country is going to survive."[18] And he saw this as both a strategic and a political problem.